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The Benefit of the Doubt: Merold Westphal's Prophetic Philosophy of Religion

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In recent years, several scholars in the United States have exploited the implications of Continental philosophy for developing new and innovative approaches to religious and theological studies. These thinkers'including, but not limited to Carl A. Raschke, Mark Taylor, Charles Winquist, Edith Wyschogrod, and John Caputo'have embraced various expressions of European philosophy, not in order to offer simple commentaries on those expressions but to utilize them as raw material for developing a uniquely American species of philosophical theology. These new American philosophical voices speak critically and constructively to the biblical paradigms lying behind Western theory, to the traditional religious and theological themes developing out of those paradigms, and to the cultural and social transformations that have changed how those paradigms are appropriated.

Toward an Apologetic for Paralogetics

- > There is, it seems to us,
- > At best, only a limited value
- > In the knowledge derived from experience.
- > The knowledge imposes a pattern and falsifies,
- > For the pattern is new in every moment
- > And every moment is a new and shocking
- > Valuation of all we have been (81-87)

Human beings always experience reality from finite perspectives, always standing between some

- > Do not let me hear
- > Of the wisdom of old men, but rather of their folly,
- > Their fear of fear and frenzy, their fear of possession,
- > Of belonging to another, or to others, or to God. (93-97)

Since individuals are never born *_in vacuo_*, they never live outside of various world patterns

- > The only wisdom we can hope to acquire
- > Is the wisdom of humility: humility is endless (97-98).

Westphal's prophetic paradigm seeks this very wisdom and teaches that humility'the fear of the

Notes

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